

Chapter 5

Beyond the State—Innovative Forms of Exchange



Compounded by more than three years of travel restrictions and policy limitations due to the COVID-19 pandemic that severely disrupted exchange both at the official and the person-to-person level, China's reputation, already burdened by bias and misconception, has had a harder time recovering compared with its economic recovery that has surpassed most of the rest of the world.

From high-level academic exchange to China's efforts to better engage with a global audience and present itself in a positive light, progress has been slow and difficult, fraught with challenges that are not easily overcome.

China Is Key to Global Exchange

China is back in its historic position of being a major global player is beyond doubt. Economically, politically and culturally, China is now a part of everyday life and there is no turning back. This is also true in the realm of exchange. China is and should continue to be a major driver of exchange between countries and the first article of this chapter explores China's impact on global higher education, titled "China Still a Leading Source of Foreign Students", if examines trends among Chinese students that choose to pursue university or graduate study abroad. Drawing on a report by the Center for China and Globalization, it shows that Chinese students continue to make up the largest number of foreign students studying in the United States, Australia, and the United Kingdom. However, the study also finds that, while the majority still seek STEM oriented programs, Chinese students are diversifying their options, both in terms of destination countries and areas of study. This long-term and continued stream of students has also resulted in highly trained graduates that are increasingly deciding to return to China to develop their careers.

Unfortunately, the number of Chinese students going abroad for advanced studies far outweighs the number of students coming to study in China, especially when it comes to the United States. The next article in this chapter, "Five Ways China Can Attract US Students Back to Its Universities Again", provides an analysis of the drastic decline in the number of American students who are choosing to study in

China post-COVID as well as recommendations on how China can make itself more attractive to American students considering studying in China.

Restoring Communication through Academic Exchange

Having already discussed in detail the tensions that continue to plague US-China relations as well as the potential avenues of expansion in China's relations with the European Union, the third article in this chapter explores how exchanges at the grass-roots level, including academic exchanges can contribute to improving bilateral relations. In a complex and fluctuating global environment, exchanges and interactions at this level can mutually improve China's global reputation and result in a more stable world.

The next article in this chapter, "Research Co-operation Pays Dividends Far Beyond Academia", examines the impact of academic collaboration on issues on which states often struggle to reach consensus. Surprisingly, despite the frosty and sometimes tense interactions between the United States and China on issues such as climate change, trade, and other common issues, researchers in the two countries produced more jointly published academic journal articles than any other country pair, while Chinese students continue to make the US their top destination for advanced studies.

Changing Perspectives to Foster a More Fundamental Understanding

The fourth and final article in this chapter, "How China Can Borrow from Aristotle's 'Art of Rhetoric' to Tell Its Story Better", focuses on how China can use techniques and arguments from the Western philosophical tradition to better reach Western audiences. Recommendations focus on taking a calm, realistic, and genuine tone by leveraging logic, empathy and credibility, focusing not so much on impressive numbers, but on reaching people on a more fundamental level that makes China accessible and tangible for audiences.

Moving beyond official channels can leverage soft power and cultural contexts that influence societies, which in turn indirectly drive the policies of countries and governments. It is in everyone's interest to foster constructive perspectives for the better through people-to-people exchanges, whether they be academic, cultural or through increased the tourism between countries.

China Still a Leading Source of Foreign Students¹

Despite the challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic, China remains the largest contributor of foreign students to major global universities, while at the same time diversifying in terms of both location and academic focus.

In the grand narrative of globalization, China's economic policy of reform and opening-up over the past more than four decades has been a core theme. It has increased the flow of people across borders and in addition to drastically boosting trade and investment, it also epitomizes the essence of global interconnectivity.

In a period of cultural and intellectual exchanges between different countries that reached a level and scale that is unprecedented, China has become the world's largest source of international students. For more than a decade, China has accounted for the highest number of students in leading educational destinations in the world, reflecting the importance of education and academic excellence, in Chinese culture and preparing the Chinese people for a globalized future.

Largest Contributor of International Students

The latest report by the Center for China and Globalization says more than 1.02 million Chinese students were studying abroad at tertiary educational institutions in 2021, highlighting China's position as the largest source of overseas students in the world.

Throughout the 2022–23 academic year, China remained the leading source of international students, with Chinese students exhibiting a significant presence in leading destinations for international students. In the United States, for example, China was the largest source of foreign students for that academic year, with about 289,000 students. It has maintained this top position for 15 years, followed closely by India.

In Canada, India had the highest number of international students, followed by China, which had about 100,000 students in the North American country in the 2021–22 academic year. Australia echoes the pattern in the US, with China being the primary source of international students, contributing about 162,826 students in 2022–23.

The United Kingdom saw a steady rise in the number of Chinese students during the COVID-19 pandemic, with their number reaching 158,335 in the 2022–23 academic year, although the growth rate of Indian students was higher than that of Chinese students.

Germany and France hosted relatively small but significant numbers of Chinese students (about 40,000 in Germany and 29,000 in France). Japan, too, has a sizable number of Chinese students—about 103,000.

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Diversified Destinations for Chinese Students

The Center for China and Globalization report also highlights a dynamic widening of destinations for Chinese students. As information on higher studies abroad becomes increasingly transparent, students can now also choose to study in less familiar educational destinations. This shift has led to a diversification of education destinations beyond the traditional Western countries.

Historically, Chinese students have favored developed countries such as the US, the UK, Australia, Canada, and Japan for overseas studies. However, a growing number of countries and regions are also becoming attractive to Chinese students. Germany and New Zealand, known for their excellent educational institutions and cost-effective standards of living, are both examples.

Additionally, emerging overseas education destinations in Southeast Asia (Singapore, Malaysia, and Thailand) and Europe (Russia, Belarus, Italy, Ukraine, Ireland, Spain, Sweden, and Switzerland) have made it to the list of top 20 overseas education destinations for Chinese students. They host thousands, and in some cases tens of thousands, of Chinese students.

Other countries such as Türkiye, Finland, Denmark, and Poland each host more than a thousand Chinese students, while Middle Eastern countries such as Saudi Arabia and Iran, and South American nations such as Argentina and Brazil also host hundreds of Chinese students.

Students' Preference for STEM Courses

Chinese students continue to favor STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics) courses, while their interest in disciplines such as business and management has declined. The 2023 Open Doors Report shows a shift in Chinese students' major preferences in the US, with an increase of 62.5 percent in STEM courses in 2022–23 — much higher than the average for all international students. On the other hand, the number of Chinese students taking up business administration courses in the US has declined from 24.3 percent to 13.4 percent since the 2015–16 academic year. The trend in Australia and Germany is similar.

Simultaneously, the reasons Chinese students choose to study abroad are diversifying, for instance, they seek greater international exposure and want to widen their vision and engage in cross-cultural exchanges. This development is reflected not only in their increasing choice of education destinations but also in the shift toward more diverse fields of study and more personalized educational experiences.

For example, France has become a preferred destination for Chinese students interested in the humanities, arts, and languages, with 40 percent of the Chinese students in France enrolled in these courses. This trend underscores the growing demand for personalized development, which is linked to new industries and career paths.

Drastic Increase in Overseas Returnees

An increasing number of Chinese students are returning home after completing their studies abroad, with returnees outnumbering new overseas students in 2020 and surpassing the one million mark in 2021. Since the launch of reform and opening-up, more than six million Chinese overseas graduates have returned to the country and played a crucial role in China's modernization. This represents a pattern of circular mobility, influenced by global corporate activity and increased international engagement.

In fact, overseas returnees dominate multiple fields. In 2023, for example, 57.9 percent of the newly appointed academics in the Chinese Academy of Sciences, the Chinese Academy of Engineering, and other institutions and organizations were overseas returnees. Specifically, 81.4 percent of new Chinese Academy of Sciences' appointees and 39.2 percent of the fresh Chinese Academy of Engineering's recruits had overseas education experience.

According to the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security, as of 2023, individuals with overseas degrees headed over 70 percent of key national projects, accounted for about 40 percent of national science and technology award winners, and occupied the president's post in more than 70 percent of the universities under the Ministry of Education and the director's position in most top-tier hospitals.

Overseas returnees have made significant contributions to China's innovation capacity, entrepreneurship and emerging sectors, especially in high-tech and the new economy. Starting in 1992, overseas returnees began establishing leading companies such as Baidu, Ctrip, and Meituan, marking a pivotal shift toward a market-oriented economy and increased sustainability.

By July 2023, an increasing number of overseas returnees were playing significant roles in China's governance, with a substantial percentage of high-ranking government officials being overseas returnees.

This blend of entrepreneurial vigor and involvement in governance underscores the vital role overseas returnees have played in working out and implementing China's domestic policies.

The government, on its part, has implemented favorable policies to help overseas returnees, particularly budding entrepreneurs. In 2017, for example, the State Council introduced the "Support Program for Overseas Educated Personnel Returning to China for Innovation and Entrepreneurship", which included sub-programs promoting innovation.

Expanding Global Reach of Chinese Enterprises

Overseas returnees have also been playing a key role in expanding Chinese enterprises' global reach and localizing multinational corporations in China. They have helped Chinese enterprises get listed on overseas stock exchanges, strike merger and

acquisition deals and establish overseas production units. In fact, they have been involved in the listing of about 80 percent of Chinese companies on Nasdaq.

They have also facilitated the smooth integration of multinational corporations into the Chinese market, enhancing China's economic globalization.

Moreover, overseas returnees have contributed to people-to-people diplomacy and cultural exchanges, boosting China's image abroad and its diplomatic relations, as emphasized by the country's top leader at the 110th anniversary of the Western Returned Scholars Association.

China remains committed to promoting economic globalization, with initiatives such as the Belt and Road Initiative, demonstrating its global engagement in different fields, including education and diplomacy.

This commitment, strengthened by President Xi's aspiration to welcome 50,000 US students to China made during his meeting with US President Joe Biden at the APEC meeting in San Francisco last November, reflects a broader policy of openness and people-to-people exchanges, which is vital for developing mutual understanding and facilitating cooperation. China's continued efforts to foster international cultural exchanges are a testament to its ethos of reform and opening-up.

These and other dynamic developments highlight the momentum of the Chinese economy's continual integration with the global economy.

Five Ways China Can Attract US Students Back to Its Universities Again²

The decline in the number of American students studying in China is alarming and could impact China-US ties. China should explore ways to attract American students and other global talent.

Amid the turbulence of China-US relations, a stabilising force has stood the test of time: exchanges between people, particularly educational exchanges. International students are a bedrock of ties, with their experiences fostering understanding and building vital bridges between the two nations. As the world's leading destination for international students, the US has long attracted Chinese students seeking a top-notch education and cross-cultural experiences.

A recent report on international talent mobility by the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), highlights the pivotal role of the US in shaping global talent flows. Despite geopolitical tensions, Chinese enthusiasm for an American education remains unabated. In 2023, the number of Chinese students in the US rebounded to 77.7 per cent of pre-pandemic levels in 2019. China remained the largest source of international students in the US, according to CCG research, demonstrating the unwavering appeal of American universities.

But educational exchanges should not be a one-way street. As China continues on its development journey, it is imperative to attract more international students, especially from the US. While China has made strides in this regard, there is still room for improvement.

In a worrying trend, the number of Americans studying in China has plummeted in recent years. US ambassador to China Nicholas Burns revealed at a Brookings Institution talk last December that the figure had fallen to just 700, a sharp decline from the 15,000 recorded six or seven years ago. "Last year [2022], we were down to 350 American students in all of China," he noted.

This year, we expect to see an increase in the number of American students coming to China, including at US-China partnership campuses such as the Duke Kunshan University, NYU Shanghai, Wenzhou-Kean University, Tianjin Juilliard School and Hopkins-Nanjing Centre.

But there is still a stark imbalance in educational exchanges and this underscores the need for China to enhance its appeal as a study destination. Doing so would not only enrich its higher education landscape but also contribute to more balanced and robust exchanges between the peoples of both countries.

To achieve this, China can draw inspiration from the CCG report's recommendations and take the following steps to create a more welcoming environment for international students.

First, streamlining visa policies and application processes would make it easier for American students to study in China. Introducing more flexible visa categories,

² First published on June 20, 2024 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

such as internship visas for STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics) students and talent visas for outstanding graduates, would incentivise more Americans to consider China as a study destination.

Second, China should strive to create a more inclusive environment for international students by encouraging an open and inclusive public attitude towards international students. This would deepen people's understanding of their role in fostering cultural exchange, creating a more welcoming social environment.

Third, internationalising curricula and expanding English-taught programmes would cater to the needs and preferences of international students. Chinese universities should be encouraged to develop interdisciplinary and globally oriented courses that better align with the interests of American students.

Fourth, enhancing the living environment for international students is crucial. Efforts should be made to address practical challenges, such as facilitating mobile payments for foreigners and providing convenient internet access. Schools and communities can use their unique resource advantages to provide language training and cultural adaptation programmes for international students. Creating a more internationalised campus atmosphere and offering tailored support services would help international students feel more at home in China.

Fifth, promoting cultural exchange programmes and partnerships between Chinese and American universities would foster deeper understanding and collaboration. Encouraging joint research projects, faculty exchanges, and student mobility programmes would create more opportunities for meaningful interactions between Chinese and American students.

While implementing these measures, China can also draw lessons from the US approach to attracting international students. The CCG report highlights the US strategy of offering scholarships, simplifying visa processes and providing employment opportunities for international graduates. By adopting similar practices and tailoring them to the Chinese context, China can enhance its competitiveness in the global race for talent.

China's recent efforts to boost international tourism provide a solid foundation for attracting more foreign students. In the first quarter of this year, inbound tourism in China exhibited a strong recovery, with more than four times as many foreign visitors as the same period last year, according to the National Immigration Administration.

The easing of travel restrictions and improvement of tourism infrastructure have made China a more accessible and appealing destination. Building upon these achievements, China can further develop its education tourism sector, showcasing its rich cultural heritage and modern advancements to potential international students.

As the CCG report emphasises, people-to-people exchanges are not only essential to promote understanding and friendship between nations but also to drive economic growth and innovation. By attracting more American students to study in China, the country can tap a diverse pool of talent, foster cross-cultural collaboration and contribute to the development of a more interconnected and cooperative world.

In a time of geopolitical challenges, educational exchanges serve as a powerful reminder of the shared aspirations and common humanity that bind us. By investing in exchanges and creating a more welcoming environment for international students, China can strengthen the foundations of its relationship with the US and pave the way to a brighter future of mutual understanding and cooperation.

Research Co-operation Pays Dividends Far Beyond Academia³

Despite rising frictions and fluctuations in cross-border educational exchange, the quiet persistence of research co-operation and academic collaboration on an individual level remains strong, generating mutual cultural understanding and goodwill.

Global flows of students, scholars, and ideas have soared over the past two decades, proving to be one of the most resilient aspects of globalization. By 2019, the number of higher-education students in a foreign country hit six million, triple the number from 2000, while almost one-quarter of all scientific publications had cross-border co-authors, up from 18.6% in 2011. This exchange has created incalculable value in interpersonal connections, economic benefits and in collaborative research such as the Human Genome Project and COVID-19 vaccines.

Nowhere has the growth in global academic exchange been more visible than in exchange between the United States and China. In the decade since the 2009–10 academic year, the number of Chinese students on American campuses almost tripled to 372,532. China and America are by far the largest bilateral-research collaborators, with more than 300,000 co-authored publications between 2017 and 2021. According to the Nature Index, which tracks such collaborations, between 2015 and 2020 the number of China-US co-authored papers in top-tier journals rose by more than that of any other international pairing.

However, there are signs that this tide of co-operation may be ebbing, owing to both the pandemic and politics. In the first half of 2022, the number of Chinese applicants granted US student visas dropped to 31,055—less than half of pre-COVID levels. Meanwhile the number of American students in China has fallen from perhaps thousands to perhaps hundreds.

That slowdown is starting to show in research databases. An analysis for *Nature*, found that in 2021 China-US co-publications fell for the first time, while the number of researchers with dual China-US affiliations had dropped by more than 20% over the previous three years.

COVID-19 and its attendant mobility restrictions are part of the dynamic, reducing the flow of researchers in both directions. But signs of reduced exchange were visible before the pandemic. And similar drops were not reflected between China and other major partners. In Britain, for example, higher-education applications from China soared by 59% between 2019 and 2022, and co-authored papers continue to rise. Meanwhile, in research conducted at the Center for China and Globalization, we found that more Chinese students are increasingly going to Asian countries where it is felt they will be safer and less likely to be discriminated against.

Geopolitical and trade tensions dating from the Trump administration have also contributed to the chill. For example, the China Initiative, a Trump-era national-security programme focused on scholars and projects with a connection to China,

³ First published on October 14, 2022 by *The Economist* and revised for this collection.

faced claims of racial targeting and misconduct by the FBI before it was wound down in February.

At a time of rising friction and global challenges, the revival and strengthening of China-US academic co-operation matters more than ever and provides numerous benefits. First, bilateral exchange in education and science has huge benefits for both economies. In 2019–20, Chinese students contributed an estimated \$15.9 billion to America's economy. They represented 35% of the international—student body and often pay full tuition fees, on which many hard-pressed institutions depend. Many Chinese academics who remain in America contribute in key sectors such as technology and finance, while those who return to China are a crucial force in spurring entrepreneurship and innovation.

Second, China-US research collaboration remains critical for addressing climate change, public health crises, and other challenges that no country can handle alone. Over the past five years, China and America each accounted for about one-fifth of the world's scientific journal articles. Together they have 3.3 million research personnel, about 37% of the global total. Yet there is a risk that current tensions could affect scientific co-operation for decades to come, given that collaborative links endure long after students return home.

Finally, academic exchange is vital for stabilising and strengthening what is likely to be the most consequential bilateral relationship of the twenty-first century. Nothing can replace directly experiencing another country. Interactions with local colleagues are a catalyst for deeper interpersonal and commercial ties, trust, and a sense of connection that can withstand bilateral frictions. Cultural relations built through academic exchange can provide a route for dialogue when other channels may be difficult.

Crucially, academic exchange is key for the next generation of Chinese and American policymakers, scientists and entrepreneurs to understand and work with each other. A survey conducted this year shows that Chinese people with experience studying or travelling in America have more-positive attitudes toward the country. It is also important that more American students cross the Pacific to study, learn Chinese and build a pipeline of China literacy for the future.

There is hope that, as the pandemic recedes, China will open its borders and America will move on from the Trump administration's ill-conceived policies, so that academic exchange can begin to recover and fulfil its vast potential. China is lifting barriers to foreign students, and more are expected after this weekend's 20th Communist Party Congress.

Those collaborations that have continued provide promising evidence that long-held professional ties have remained strong. Away from the headlines, scientists continue to co-operate quietly on ground-breaking research in fields from astronomy and climate science to oncology, where researchers in New York and Guangzhou are running world-first joint clinical trials. We should hope that such exchanges are a model for the future. In a world where collaborative research holds the key to overcoming our greatest challenges, we cannot afford for the two science superpowers to be divided.

How China Can Borrow from Aristotle's "Art of Rhetoric" to Tell Its Story Better⁴

China's reputation faces biases and misconceptions throughout the world despite its impressive achievements and contributions to global development. By using classic Aristotelian concepts of logos, pathos, and ethos, perhaps China can better reach Western and even global audiences.

We've come a long way since the writer Lu Xun bemoaned the plight of a "voiceless China" to an audience at the Hong Kong YMCA nearly a century ago. Today, China has built the world's largest diplomatic network, a globe-spanning media organisation, and plays a prominent role in multilateral organisations.

The country is one of the world's great developmental success stories and its handling of the pandemic has been remarkable by any measure.

Yet negative views of the country persist abroad and have increased in advanced economies since the outbreak of COVID-19, according to the latest survey by the Pew Research Center.

What explains this gap between China's achievements and its international image? Geopolitics, cultural differences, and the global media hegemony of the West are surely part of the answer. China's image is often coloured by misunderstandings, stereotypes or biased reporting.

Even so, those who "speak for China" could do more to nurture a national image that is credible, admirable, and respectable. Simply having a voice is not enough. It must also be used to tell stories that global audiences find persuasive.

For a guide in this endeavour, one could do worse than to pick Aristotle. The Greek philosopher laid out principles that have shaped Western rhetoric since ancient times. His *Art of Rhetoric* is one of the most important works ever written on the topic of persuasion.

At the heart of Aristotle's theory is a trinity of elements and how they work together: logos, pathos, and ethos.

First comes logos—appealing to reason. When facing false claims or distortions, people speaking for China should remain calm and construct rational counter arguments. In our current charged atmosphere, it is all too easy to react impulsively to unreasonable attacks and try to fight fire with fire. But such responses will not win over sceptical audiences unless they are based on solid logic and empirical evidence.

China's story is full of mind-boggling numbers: 800 million people who have been lifted out of extreme poverty; a vast market set to import over US\$22 trillion worth of goods over the next decade; a 2 billion vaccine doses pledge to other countries, and the promise of 36,000 square kilometres (14,000 square miles) of newly planted forest each year.

These facts and figures are proof of China's contribution to global growth and public goods. They appeal to the interest of nations and people around the world and are powerful tools to deploy in the name of logos.

⁴ First published on February 19, 2022 by SCMP and revised for this collection.

However, when it comes to persuasion, Aristotle reminds us that logic alone is not enough. To sway an audience, pathos—emotional appeal—is also important.

One way to create emotional resonance is to frame issues in terms of themes and values shared by global audiences. Another is to bring narratives to life with relatable characters.

The importance of characters in storytelling is universal and a widely held belief in modern public relations and marketing. Recent research has even found that character-based narratives cause the synthesis of oxytocin, a neurochemical that motivates people to cooperate.

Telling stories imbued with human pathos is especially important in a fragmented era when all things local are making a comeback. Stories about abstract processes like “globalization” or “the rise of China” are complex and difficult to comprehend. They can even cause anxiety—especially when shaped by malign interests.

Macro narratives should be fleshed out at a more human scale to make them more resonant. For example, there could be vivid portraits of how poverty alleviation changes the lives of individual farmers and families, or how the Belt and Road Initiative benefits overseas communities at the grass-roots level.

This brings us to the persuasive power of ethos, which rests on the credibility, authority, and moral character of the speaker. Without ethos, appeals to logic and emotion may not be trusted in the first place.

To establish ethos, those speaking for China must be willing to engage and build rapport with others who may have different world views or preconceptions. This means accepting invitations to speak to the foreign media and public audiences, instead of refusing because they might be critical.

Ethos requires a willingness to listen and converse in good faith, a recognition that confidence and humility are not mutually exclusive, and that to be tolerant is not to lack a firm stance.

The need to engage and promote constructive dialogue is a key theme of *Engage the World on China*, a recent book by the Center for China and Globalization. It recounts the think tank’s efforts to connect with global audiences on stages such as Davos, the Munich Security Conference, and the Paris Peace Forum.

An effective way to boost credibility and emotional pull at the same time is to empower a diversity of voices to tell stories about China, forming an eclectic non-governmental discourse that spans policy, business, culture, and everyday life.

Social media allows anyone to tell their story—young or old, male or female, rural or urban, from any walk of life. Giving voice to these stories will help to convey the diversity and complexity of China, unlike simplistic narratives that reduce the lives of 1.4 billion people to narrow tropes or political issues.

Scholars can support this polyphonic model of storytelling by drawing on their specialist expertise and research to frame and discuss China’s development, challenges and solutions in the language of social science and other disciplines.

Non-governmental voices can be more enterprising in shaping the terms of the debate on China by using diplomatic backchannels and developing new multilateral platforms for exchange.

When it comes to speaking for China, Aristotle reminds us that an acerbic tone does not help convince others; that facts and figures are important, but that China's story cannot be told in terms of GDP and bilateral trade alone. China has a great story to tell and a diverse cast of calm but proactive voices are needed to tell it.

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